Tenses and Modals

The big idea

Tenses tell us **when** an action happens; **modals** tell us the speaker's **attitude** to an action — ability, permission, possibility, obligation and so on. In the board exam, these appear in **gap-filling**, **editing** and **omission** questions, so you need to spot the right form quickly.

The twelve tenses at a glance

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect Continuous
Present	She **writes**	She **is writing**	She **has written**	She **has been writing**
Past	She **wrote**	She **was writing**	She **had written**	She **had been writing**
Future	She **will write**	She **will be writing**	She **will have written**	She **will have been writing**

When to use each tense

Present tense

- **Simple present:** habits, general truths, timetables. *The sun **rises** in the east. The train **leaves** at 6 p.m.*
- **Present continuous:** actions happening now or planned soon. *They **are playing** cricket. I **am meeting** him tomorrow.*

- **Present perfect:** a past action with a result now; with *just, already, yet, ever, never, since, for*. *I **have finished** my homework. She **has lived** here since 2015.*
- **Present perfect continuous:** an action that began in the past and is still going on. *It **has been raining** for two hours.*

Past tense

- **Simple past:** completed action at a definite past time. *Mandela **became** President in 1994.*
- **Past continuous:** an action in progress in the past, often interrupted. *I **was reading** when the lights **went** out.*
- **Past perfect:** the earlier of two past actions. *The train **had left** before we **reached** the station.*
- **Past perfect continuous:** an action continuing up to a point in the past. *He **had been waiting** for an hour when the bus came.*

Future tense

- **Simple future:** *I **will help** you.*
- **Future continuous:** *This time tomorrow, we **will be flying** to Delhi.*
- **Future perfect:** *By next June, she **will have completed** the course.*

QUICK PATTERNS

Continuous = be + verb-ing. Perfect = have/has/had + past participle (V3). Perfect continuous = have/has/had + been + verb-ing.

"SINCE" VS "FOR"

Since + a point of time (since Monday, since 2010). **For** + a length of time (for three days, for ten years).

NO PRESENT PERFECT WITH A DEFINITE PAST TIME

× *I have seen him yesterday.* ✓ *I **saw** him yesterday.*

Subject–verb agreement reminders

- Singular subject → singular verb: *Each of the boys **has** a book.*
- *Neither… nor / Either… or*: the verb agrees with the nearer subject. *Neither the teacher nor the students **were** present.*
- Uncountable nouns take singular verbs: *The news **is** good. Furniture **is** expensive.*

Modals

Modals are helping verbs followed by the **base form** of the verb (no -s, -ed, -ing). *She can **swim**.* (not *can swims*)

Modal	Use	Example
can	ability, informal permission	*I can speak French. Can I go out?*
could	past ability, polite request, possibility	*She could run fast as a child. Could you help me?*
may	formal permission, possibility, wish	*May I come in? It may rain. May you live long!*
might	weaker possibility	*He might come late.*
must	strong obligation, necessity, strong deduction	*You must wear a helmet. He must be tired.*
mustn't	prohibition	*You mustn't smoke here.*
should / ought to	advice, moral duty	*You should respect elders. We ought to help the poor.*
will / shall	future, promise, determination	*I will help you. Shall we start?*

Modal	Use	Example
would	polite request, past habit, conditional	*Would you pass the salt? He would walk daily.*
need (not)	necessity / absence of necessity	*You needn't hurry.*
dare	courage	*How dare you!*
used to	past habit	*I used to live in Pune.*

"MUST NOT" VS "NEED NOT"

*You **must not** go* = you are forbidden. *You **need not** go* = it is not necessary, but you may.

GAP-FILLING (BOARD STYLE)

The doctor told him that he ___ (advice) eat less sugar. → **should**
___ I borrow your pen, please? (formal permission) → **May**
She ___ (ability, past) read when she was four. → **could**
The ground is wet; it ___ (deduction) have rained. → **must**

EDITING WITH TENSES

*Yesterday I go to the market and buy apples. → Yesterday I **went** to the market and **bought** apples.*
*He is working here since 2019. → He **has been working** here since 2019.*

EXAM STRATEGY

Look for **time markers** (yesterday, since, by next year, now) to choose the tense, and for the **function** (advice, permission, obligation) to choose the modal. Keep the tense consistent in a paragraph unless time changes.

Quick recap

- 12 tenses: present/past/future × simple/continuous/perfect/perfect continuous.
- Since = point of time; for = period.
- Modals + base verb; can/could (ability), may/might (permission/possibility), must (obligation/deduction), should/ought to (advice), need not (no necessity).

Practice questions

1. Choose the correct form: She ___ in this school since 2018.
   (a) teaches (b) is teaching (c) has been teaching (d) taught
2. When I reached the station, the train ___.
   (a) left (b) had already left (c) has left (d) leaves
3. Which modal expresses a formal request for permission?
   (a) Can (b) Must (c) May (d) Should
4. "You ___ not buy a ticket; entry is free." Choose the modal.
   (a) must (b) need (c) may (d) dare
5. Identify the correct sentence.
   (a) I have seen him yesterday. (b) He can swims well. (c) Neither the boys nor the teacher were present. (d) Each of the students has a book.
6. The ground is wet. It ___ have rained last night. (logical deduction)
   (a) must (b) should (c) would (d) need
7. By this time next year, she ___ her degree.
   (a) completes (b) will complete (c) has completed (d) will have completed
8. Fill in the blanks with suitable forms of the verbs or modals: Yesterday Riya (a) ___ (go) to the library. She (b) ___ (read) for two hours when her friend called. Her mother says she (c) ___ (advice) take a break now and then.

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. b 5. d 6. a 7. d 8. see notes